

Australian Defence Force deployments pose a biosecurity risk to Australia through the movement of contaminated vehicles, machinery, equipment and personal items providing a route for the entry of exotic pests and disease. The following information provides guidance on Australian biosecurity requirements associated with Australian Defence Force personnel returning to Australia from an overseas mission.

All personnel equipment will be inspected by biosecurity officers either prior to departure or on entry into Australia. Should contamination be detected on inspection of any item, further cleaning will be required. Returning Australian Defence Force personnel are required to ensure all items of clothing and equipment are clean and free of seed, plant material, soil, insects and animals, as detailed in the list below.

Cleaning instruction video

Introduction

This is the accessible text transcript of the Military Policy – Pack and Webbing Awareness video.

Transcript

[Video begins]

[00:00:00 – 00:00:10] [Video description: Opening slide with name of video.]

[Audio]: Welcome to the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry Military Pack and Webbing awareness video.

[00:00:10 – 00:00:35] [Video description: text panel over an image of the Biosecurity Act 2015.]

[Audio]: Our department is responsible for regulating the biosecurity risks of goods and persons arriving into Australia under the Biosecurity Act 2015. It is important to know that under this Act, severe consequences can be applied to individuals who do not comply with our biosecurity requirements, including infringement notices up to 20 penalty units.

[00:00:35 – 00:01:09] [Video description: text panel over an image of an officer in a forest.]

[Audio]: Military deployments to Australia pose a biosecurity risk to Australia through the movement of contaminated vehicles, machinery, equipment and personal items provided a route for the entry of exotic pests and diseases. Both returning Australian and visiting foreign defence force personnel are required to ensure that all items of clothing and field equipment are clean and free of soil, seeds, plant material, insects and animals.

[00:01:09 – 00:01:30] [Video description: still images of soil, seeds down the tongue of boots, an ant on a bag.]

[Audio]: Some examples may be soil, like materials such as dirt, mud and clay. Plant material, like seeds, grass and leaves. And animal material, such as live ants or spiders, live or dead animals, including frogs or rodents, and animal faeces.

[00:01:30 - 00:01:43] [Video description: an officer cleaning a boot with a gun brush, scraping a bag with a pocketknife, using duct tape within the bag to clean, and a flashlight looking into the bag.]

[Audio]: In most cases you can easily clean all your equipment with the help of simple tools, such as gun brush, vacuum, pocketknife, duct tape with the help of a flashlight or headlight.

[00:01:43 – 00:01:53] [Video description: slow pan over pack contents.]

[Audio]: Think about your field pack and its contents and how best to check everything. It is recommended that you take a systematic and thorough approach.

[00:01:53 – 00:02:08] [Video description: an officer turning the pack inside out, feeling the seams along the bag and hitting the back of the bag.]

[Audio]: Where possible, turn items inside out, pay attention to the seams, the bottom of packs, pouches or where there may be damage or the design that may have created a cavity or aperture where seeds, soil or insects may imbed.

[00:02:08 – 00:02:37] [Video description: an officer unpacking his equipment from the pack and laying it out on a table.]

[Audio]: A good starting point is to fully unpack your field kit (ALICE pack), backpack or dive bag, including all pouches and pockets and lay all the contents onto a table or clean surface.

[00:02:37 – 00:02:46] [Video description: contents of the pack sitting on the table.]

[Audio]: This will allow you to easily check the Pack and each of the contents within the pack for any biosecurity risk material.

[00:02:46 -00:03:14] [Video description: an officer unwinding tape from multiple pack straps.]

[Audio]: Commencing with the empty field pack or backpack, first thing is to look for any electrical tape. While tape is a great item to have in or on your pack, biosecurity risk material, especially plant material and seeds, often adheres to this tape. Go through the pack and make sure all tape is removed, including from pack straps and medical kits.

[00:03:14 -00:03:44] [Video description: an officer peeling Velcro apart and scraping each Velcro side with a gun brush and knife.]

[Audio]: The next step is to check any Velcro. While it is incredibly practical for holding things together or in place, it is just as effective for harbouring plant material, especially seeds. Velcro is commonly found on most field packs and the material will need to be separated so it can be checked on both sides and cleaned if required. For any biosecurity risk material found within Velcro, a gun brush or pocket-knife have been found to be very effective in removing contamination.

[00:03:44 -00:03:52] [Video description: the outside of the pack plus individual pouches.]

[Audio]: Check the external surfaces of your pack, including all affixed or non-affixed pouches.

[00:03:52 – 00:04:09] [Video description: an officer using a flashlight looking into the body of the pack and then using a brush to scrape Velcro.]

[Audio]: Using a flashlight or headlight will allow you to check these external pockets, some of which can be quite deep. As some of these pouches can also be quite slender, inverting the pack and tapping can also be an effective method to dislodge and remove risk material.

[00:04:09 – 00:04:38] [Video description: an officer brushing Velcro with a gun brush on individual pouches attached to a belt, putting the brush down between small apertures.]

[Audio]: On some field kits, these pouches can be sewn to the pack, while others are affixed with clips or only spot sewn onto the pack. If affixed by clips, remove the pouches to allow for checking and if spot sewn, make sure you check these little apertures too.

[00:04:38 – 00:05:03] [Video description: still image of a metal support frame with soil and a plastic support frame.]

[Audio]: If your Pack has a metal support frame, it is recommended that this is removed to allow thorough checking to where this attaches to the Pack. Some plastic frames can also be removed, facilitating cleaning. With the metal frames, check the underside to ensure the frame tube is not filled with soil. Once we have thoroughly examined the outside of the pack, now let's focus on the internal.

[00:05:03 – 00:05:36] [Video description: an officer shaking the pack, opening the zip inside the pack and shaking it again.]

[Audio]: Check for internal zips and open any pockets so they can be examined. Some Packs have an internal zipper that separates the internal into a topside and bottom. Undo this zip. As gravity will often see risk materials fall to the lowest point, with the bottom of the pack, it can be a good idea to invert the base of the Pack so the internal seams can be checked and cleaned. Once the Pack has been thoroughly checked both internally and externally, let's now focus on the contents.

[00:05:36 – 00:05:47] [Video description: an officer taking out drink bottles from pouches and shaking the pouches.]

[Audio]: Remove the empty water bottles from their pouch and examine, paying particular attention to the internal and external surfaces of the pouch.

[00:05:47 – 00:06:01] [Video description: an entrenching tool plus a close-up image of entrenching tool with soil attached.]

[Audio]: Remove your entrenching tool from its sleeve and check the tool for cleanliness as well as the sleeve.

[00:06:01 – 00:06:25] [Video description: an officer shaking ammunition pouches and removing medical kit from pouch.]

[Audio]: With your ammunition pouches, remove the contents and check both internally and externally and tap out any magazine clips to ensure they are internally clean. Lay out the contents of your medical kit which allows the receptacle and contents to be checked. Also remove any electrical tape from the receptacle if applicable.

[00:06:25 – 00:07:09] [Video description: an officer removing Kevlar plates, scraping all Velcro with a gun brush and opening the pouches.]

[Audio]: If you have ballistic vests or flak gear in your kit, you'll need to remove the Kevlar plates. Ballistic vests, like packs, usually have a lot of Velcro. Pull the Velcro apart to allow thorough examination and check inside the pouches where the Kevlar plates are placed.

[00:07:09 -00:07:31] [Video description: an officer brushing the inside of belt webbing and all surrounding Velcro.]

[Audio]: If your kit contains belt webbing, the same principle applies to this as the Pack. If the attached pouches are only held in place via clips, please ensure that any pouches, water bottles or other receptacles are removed. A gun brush can be used to run through any apertures to ensure free of any contamination.

[00:07:31 – 00:08:02] [Video description: an officer removing a sleeping bag from the pouch, shaking the sleeping bag and the pouch.]

[Audio]: Unroll your sleeping bag and check the external surfaces. Once the outside is checked, invert so the internal surfaces can be checked as well. A good shake out will generally remove any risk material

[00:08:02 – 00:08:13] [Video description: an officer shaking the Hootchie.]

[Audio]: The same method can be applied to the Hootchie or tarpaulin by unrolling up and giving it a good shake. If it needs to be cleaned, only roll up once it is dry.

[00:08:13 -00:08:32] [Video description: an officer removing and inspecting padding from helmet.]

[Audio]: To check your helmet, the first thing to do is remove the cover and any internal padding that is held in place by Velcro. Check the Velcro on the cover straps and the internal padding.

[00:08:32 -00:09:04] [Video description: an officer removing laces from boots, cleaning boots with gun brush, tapping boots on the table and brushing the sole.]

[Audio]: Boots are in constant contact with the ground. To get your boots ready, remove the laces and inner soles and do a thorough check. Clean the areas down beside the tongue with a gun brush. Besides checking the external surfaces, a tapping of the boots, once the inner sole has been removed is a good way to remove any internal risk material.

[00:09:04 – 00:09:17] [Video description: an officer undoing coils of rope and electrical tape.]

[Audio]: Coils of rope and anything else you can think of that holds or binds, needs to be undone so it can be checked and cleaned.

[00:09:17 – 00:09:43] [Video description: an officer shaking the mosquito net and examining it held up to the light.]

[Audio]: If you have a mosquito net, please roll this and hold the netting up to the light. This is the best way to ensure no risk material is attached. It is really important not to use high pressure water to clean your personal equipment, this often pushes biosecurity risk material into harder to reach spots or within the fabric, making cleaning more difficult.

[00:09:43 – 00:10:38] [Video description: an officer putting items back in pack and then cleaning uniform, including the inside of pockets, with gun brush.]

[Audio]: Where reasonably practical, if you can place items back into your pack separated, like your water bottle and pouch, this can expedite the inspection upon arrival. A general machine wash of your uniforms will usually suffice, however please take the time to check your numerous pockets on trousers and shirts and do a thorough inspection. Don't forget to check the Velcro on your uniforms for biosecurity risk material.

[00:10:38 – 00:11:03] [Video description: an officer separating and cleaning socks and cleaning hat with a gun brush.]

[Audio]: As for socks, please ensure that these are checked, both inside and out as grass and seeds often tend to stick to them. Where possible, leave these separated for our biosecurity officers. A successful inspection by biosecurity can be achieved with a systematic and thorough check of your field pack and all its contents.

[00:11:03 – 00:11:12] [Video description: an officer putting sleeping bag back into pack.]

[Audio]: Once you have undertaken this check and cleaning where required, store it safely to prevent contamination.

[00:11:12 -00:11:36] [Video description: text panel over an officer's arm.]

[Audio]: By taking care to clean your personal field kit correctly you are helping us keep plant and animal pests and diseases out of Australia, helping us to protect our unique environment and agricultural industries. On behalf of the department of agriculture, thank you for watching and we look forward to working with you in preparation for your arrival into Australia.

[00:11:36 – 00:11:49] [Video description: Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry logo.]

[Video ends]

[End of transcript.]

Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge the Traditional Custodians of Australia and their continuing connection to land and sea, waters, environment and community. We pay our respects to the Traditional Custodians of the lands we live and work on, their culture, and their Elders past and present.

Item	Cleaning requirements
Clothing	
Footwear	
Knives, bayonets and blades	
Webbing and packs	
Trunks	
Bags: Echelon, diver's, equipment (duffle bags)	
Helmets	
Cloth hats and caps	
Gloves	
Sleeping materials	
Stretchers	
Cover body armour and inserts	
Mosquito nets, camouflage nets and tents	
Wet weather clothing	
Rope assembly	
First aid dressing	
Cloth neck (sweat cloth)	
Shelter individual (shelter half)	
Insulation tape	

For further information please contact the Machinery and Military Team:

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Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/aircraft-vessels-military/military/adf/adf-cleaning-instructions>